further felicitated by the absence of a well-organised opposition party.'[89]

The Jan Sangh was forged in a spirit of anti-Congressism from its founding moment. As Mookerjee was to say in 1951, 'We want Jana Sangh to grow up as an opposition party and prepare itself to serve as an alternative Government of this country.' This idea was also accompanied by a deep sense of victimhood. In August 1966, Balraj Madhok, president of the party, delivered a lecture at the Ahmedabad Junior Chamber that was titled 'What Bharatiya Jana Sangh Stands For'. He started by telling his audience, which consisted of the who's who of Gujarat's magnates, 'Bharatiya Jana Sangh is the one party which has been most condemned and maligned all these years without a hearing. From the day the Jan Sangh came into being, the late Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, the ruling Congress Party and its ideological allies as also the Communist Party started their volley against it. Perhaps, they instinctively felt that this new party might trounce them one day. Even though the first general elections were held only three months after the Jana Sangh was born yet the Jan Sangh was the main target of the Congress, Pandit Nehru, the Communist Party and everybody else. So many things have been said about us—Jana Sangh is a communal party, it is a reactionary party, it has no economic programme and so on.'[90] At the heart of this conception was the fervent belief that the Congress would soon wear itself out and wither away. From the 1960s onwards, as Madhok told his listeners, the Jan Sangh was convinced that 'in the next few years *Congress Party is going to disappear* as the ruling party in the country'.[91] It is not too difficult to see how this core belief informed the slogan of 'Congress-mukt Bharat'.

The RSS and the Jan Sangh: Cadre, Control and Power Equations

From its very inception, the Jan Sangh sought to distinguish itself from the existing Hindu nationalist parties: the Hindu Mahasabha[92] and the Ram Rajya Parishad (literally, Ram Rule Assembly, which